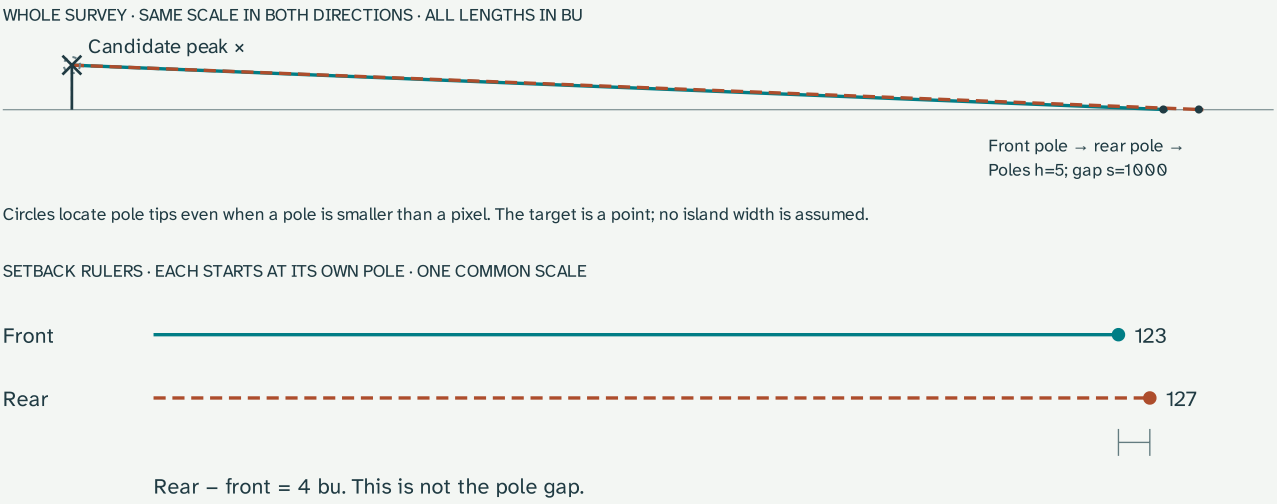
Check the second sighting.

Applied record saved at operation 6 of 6: **Check both sightings**. The complete calculated comparisons below are provided for inspection; they do not assert the operator finished the recipe.

Reopen this applied state · All lengths in bu; 6 chi = 1 bu, 10 chi = 1 zhang, 300 bu = 1 li. No conversion to metres.

Observations and current operation

h = 5; s = 1000; a = 123; b = 127 bu. Proposed divisor: difference.



Check both sightings

Put the candidate peak at x = –D. Ask each observation separately what height its line has there. A consistent peak must match both.

Both sightings agree. The peak fits the two independent observations.

At the candidate distance D = 30750 bu

Height	Exact bu
Candidate	1255
Front line	1255
Rear line	1255

Height	Exact bu
Candidate – rear	0

Modern setback intervals

Each retreat independently ±2 bu; h and s exact.

ALLOWED RETREAT DIFFERENCE

0 to 8 bu

No finite upper bound

Quantity	Smallest	Largest
Height H	630 bu	No finite upper bound
Distance D	15125 bu	No finite upper bound

Allowed forward cases approach a zero positive retreat difference. Height and distance grow without limit. Other allowed pairs may be parallel or outside the forward setup; none has been silently removed from the record.

These are exact interval bounds under the modern model, not a confidence interval. The front and rear retreats are allowed to vary independently.

Why one observation is insufficient

Front pole (0,h), rear pole (s,h), front ground eye (a,0), rear ground eye (s+b,0), island peak (–D,H). Front line: y=h(a–x)/a. Rear line: y=h(s+b–x)/b. Equating them gives D(b–a)=as and H=h+hs/(b–a).

A recipe with any nonzero divisor f produces D=as/f and H=h+hs/f, which always fit the front observation. The rear observation fits only if f=b–a. Equal retreats give parallel lines. A shorter rear retreat puts the intersection outside the forward-island setup. This is modern coordinate analysis, not a transcription of Liu Hui's proof.

This model assumes a level common baseline, equal vertical poles, point-like tips and target, and ground eyes. The chosen interval varies only setbacks; it does not include terrain, pole or eye-height errors, refraction, or any probability distribution.

READING 1 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

PROBLEM ATTRIBUTED TO LIU HUI

Place two equal poles

今有望海島，立兩表齊高三丈，前後相去千步，令後表與前表參相直。

Suppose an island is to be sighted. Set up two poles of equal height, three zhang, a thousand bu apart, front and rear. Align the rear pole with the front pole.

The alignment is along the survey direction on the ground. It does not put both pole tips and the island peak on one sight line.

表	biǎo a sighting pole
齊高	qí gāo equal in height
相去	xiāng qù to be separated by a distance

READING 2 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

PROBLEM ATTRIBUTED TO LIU HUI

Make the first sighting

從前表卻行一百二十三步，人目著地，取望島峯，與表末參合。

Retreat 123 bu from the front pole. With the eye at ground level, sight the island peak so that it lines up with the tip of the pole.

The eye is at ground level in this idealized exercise. Adding an ordinary standing eye height would change the geometry.

卻行	què xíng to move back
著地	zhuó dì touching the ground
表末	biǎo mò the tip of the pole

READING 3 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

PROBLEM ATTRIBUTED TO LIU HUI

Make the second sighting

從後表卻行一百二十七步，人目著地，取望島峯，亦與表末參合。

Retreat 127 bu from the rear pole. With the eye at ground level, sight the island peak; it too lines up with the tip of that pole.

This is a second eye position and a second pole. The two observations constrain the same peak.

後表	hòu biǎo the rear pole
亦	yì also
參合	cān hé to line up together

READING 4 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

PROBLEM ATTRIBUTED TO LIU HUI

Read the stated answers

問島高及去表各幾何？答曰：島高四里五十五步，去表一百二里一百五十步。

What are the island's height and its distance from the pole? Answer: the island is four li and 55 bu high; its distance from the pole is 102 li and 150 bu.

The distance procedure specifies the front pole. At 300 bu per li, these answers are 1,255 bu and 30,750 bu.

幾何	jǐ hé how much?
島高	dǎo gāo the height of the island
去表	qù biǎo distance from the pole

Opening 10 · Left leaf, last columns; the answer continues onto opening 11

READING 5 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

PROCEDURE ATTRIBUTED TO LIU HUI

Operate on the numbers

術曰：以表高乘表間為實，相多為法，除之。所得加表高，即得島高。

Procedure: multiply the pole height by the distance between the poles to form the dividend. Use the excess as divisor and divide. Add the pole height to the result; this gives the island's height.

實 and 法 are calculation roles here: dividend and divisor. The crucial question is what 相多, the excess, refers to.

實	shí dividend in this operation
法	fǎ divisor in this operation
相多	xiāng duō the amount by which one exceeds the other

Opening 11 · Right leaf, first main-text columns

READING 6 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

COMMENTARY ATTRIBUTED TO LI CHUNFENG AND COLLEAGUES

Try the received wording

二表相去為相多，以為法。

Use the distance between the two poles as the excess, making it the divisor.

This is the wording in the received commentary in this printed witness. Try the pole-gap divisor in the calculation. A wrong result can still pass one sighting. This does not establish when or how the wording arose.

二表	èr biǎo the two poles
以為	yǐ wéi use as
淳風等按	Chúnfēng děng àn Chunfeng and colleagues comment

Opening 11 · Right leaf, commentary ends at the left; 二表 begins near the bottom of its last column

READING 7 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

QING EDITORIAL NOTE, MARKED 案

Read the editorial correction

前後去表相減，餘四步為相多，非二表相去也。

Subtract the front and rear distances from the poles: the remaining four bu is the excess. It is not the distance between the two poles.

The small note distinguishes the setback difference, 127 – 123, from the pole gap, 1,000. The note's text crosses from the right leaf onto the top right of the left leaf.

相減	xiāng jiǎn subtract one from the other
餘	yú what remains
非…也	fēi … yě it is not …

Opening 11 · Small editorial text in the final right-leaf column and first left-leaf column

READING 8 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

PROCEDURE ATTRIBUTED TO LIU HUI

Calculate the distance

求前表去島遠近者：以前表卻行乘表間為實，相多為法，除之，得島去表數。

To find the distance from the front pole to the island: multiply the front-pole retreat by the pole gap as dividend. Use the excess as divisor and divide; this gives the distance from island to pole.

The same divisor must work in both procedures. Height needs the extra pole height; distance does not.

前表卻行	qián biǎo què xíng the retreat from the front pole
乘	chéng multiply
除之	chú zhī divide it

Opening 11 · Left leaf, middle main-text columns

READING 9 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

COMMENTARY ATTRIBUTED TO LI CHUNFENG AND COLLEAGUES

Check the worked arithmetic

前去表乘表間，得一十二萬三千步，以相多四步為法，除之，得三萬七百五十步。

Multiplying the front retreat by the pole gap gives 123,000 bu. Divide using the excess of four bu as divisor: the result is 30,750 bu.

The numerical commentary itself uses four here. The written calculation keeps the historical unit labels; our modern dimensional analysis treats the product as bu squared, divided by bu.

一十二萬三千	yī shí èr wàn sān qiān 123,000
四步	sì bù four bu
三萬七百五十	sān wàn qī bǎi wǔ shí 30,750

READING 10 OF 10 · SELECTED CLAUSE

QING BIBLIOGRAPHIC PREFACE

Acknowledge the later witness

書世無傳本，惟散見永樂大典中，今裒而輯之。

No transmitted copy of the book survives in circulation; it is found only in scattered places in the Yongle Encyclopedia. Now these have been gathered and compiled.

This preface explains the Qing compilation. The retained Waseda book is catalogued as 1777; its preface is dated 1775. These are later witnesses to an ancient work, not a third-century manuscript.

傳本	chuán běn a transmitted copy
永樂大典	Yǒnglè dàdiǎn the Yongle Encyclopedia
輯	jí to collect and compile

Opening 9 · Left leaf, first columns on the right

About the witness and renderings

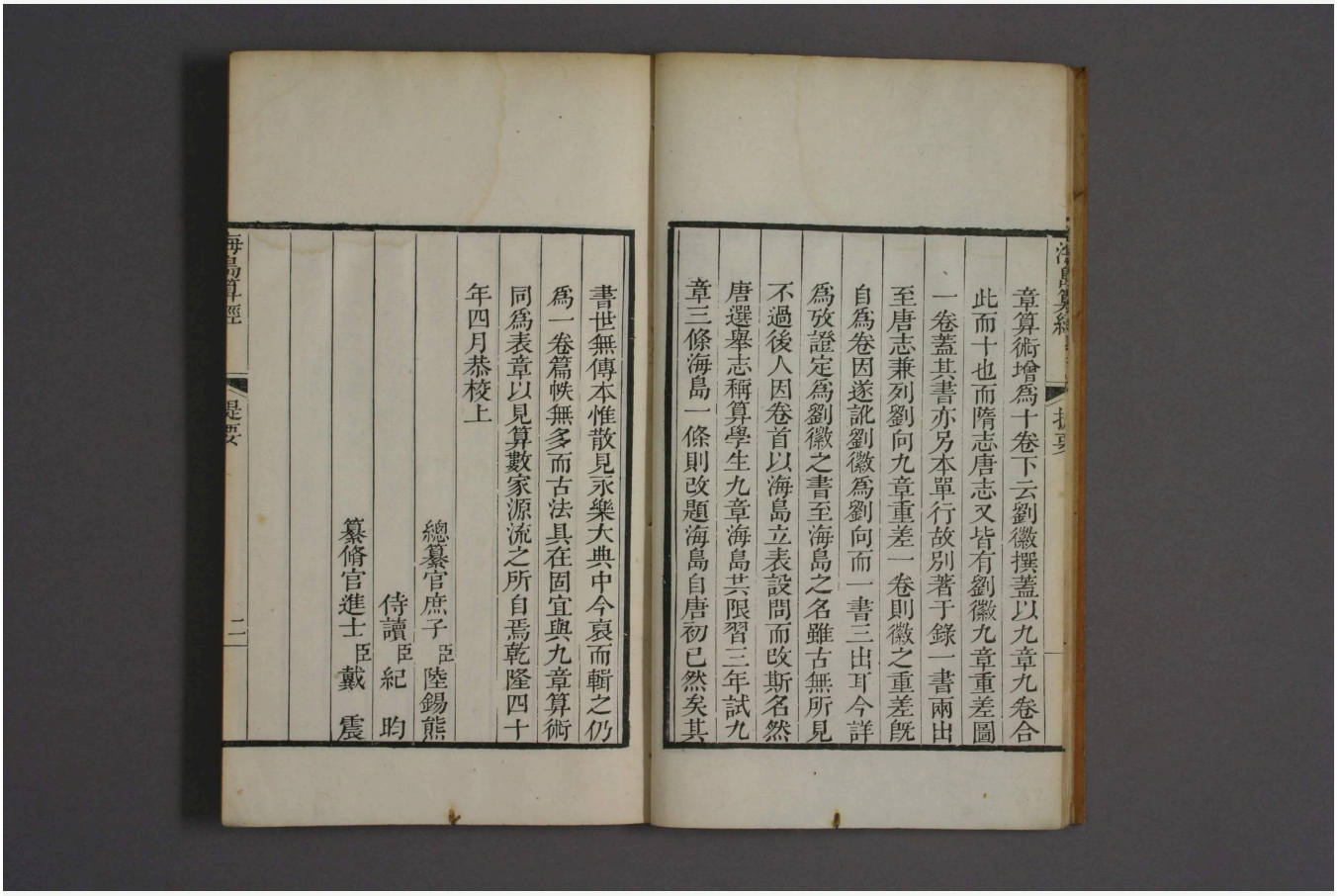
Waseda University Library ni02 00649; catalogue date 1777; preface dated 1775. The Qing preface describes compilation from scattered material in the Yongle Encyclopedia. This is a later witness to an ancient work, not a third-century manuscript. The received commentary and the small editorial correction have separate voices.

Chinese clauses were transcribed for this edition from the retained photographs. Modern punctuation is supplied; English renderings and the coordinate model are new. Modern Mandarin pinyin is a reading aid, not reconstructed ancient pronunciation. The text is excerpted; this is not a complete critical edition. The source exercise is not an identified physical expedition.

Scan and catalogue · Complete source PDF · Ang Tian Se and Frank J. Swetz (1986), historical study. That study's translation and figures are not reproduced.

Five complete photographed openings, PDF pages 9-13. Rendered by Poppler 24.02.0, longest edge 3600 pixels, JPEG quality 88; no crop or retouch.

Whole opening 9



章算術增爲十卷下云劉徽撰蓋以九章九卷合此而十也而隋志唐志又皆有劉徽九章重差圖一卷蓋其書亦另本單行故別著于錄一書兩出至唐志兼列劉向九章重差一卷則徽之重差既自爲卷因遂訛劉徽爲劉向而一書三出耳今詳爲攷證定爲劉徽之書至海島之名雖古無所見不過後人因卷首以海島立表設問而改斯名然唐選舉志稱算學生九章海島共限習三年試九章三條海島一條則改題海島自唐初已然矣其

書世無傳本惟散見永樂大典中今裒而輯之仍爲一卷篇帙無多而古法具在固宜與九章算術同爲表章以見算數家源流之所自焉乾隆四十年四月恭校上

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侍讀臣紀昀
纂脩官進士臣戴震

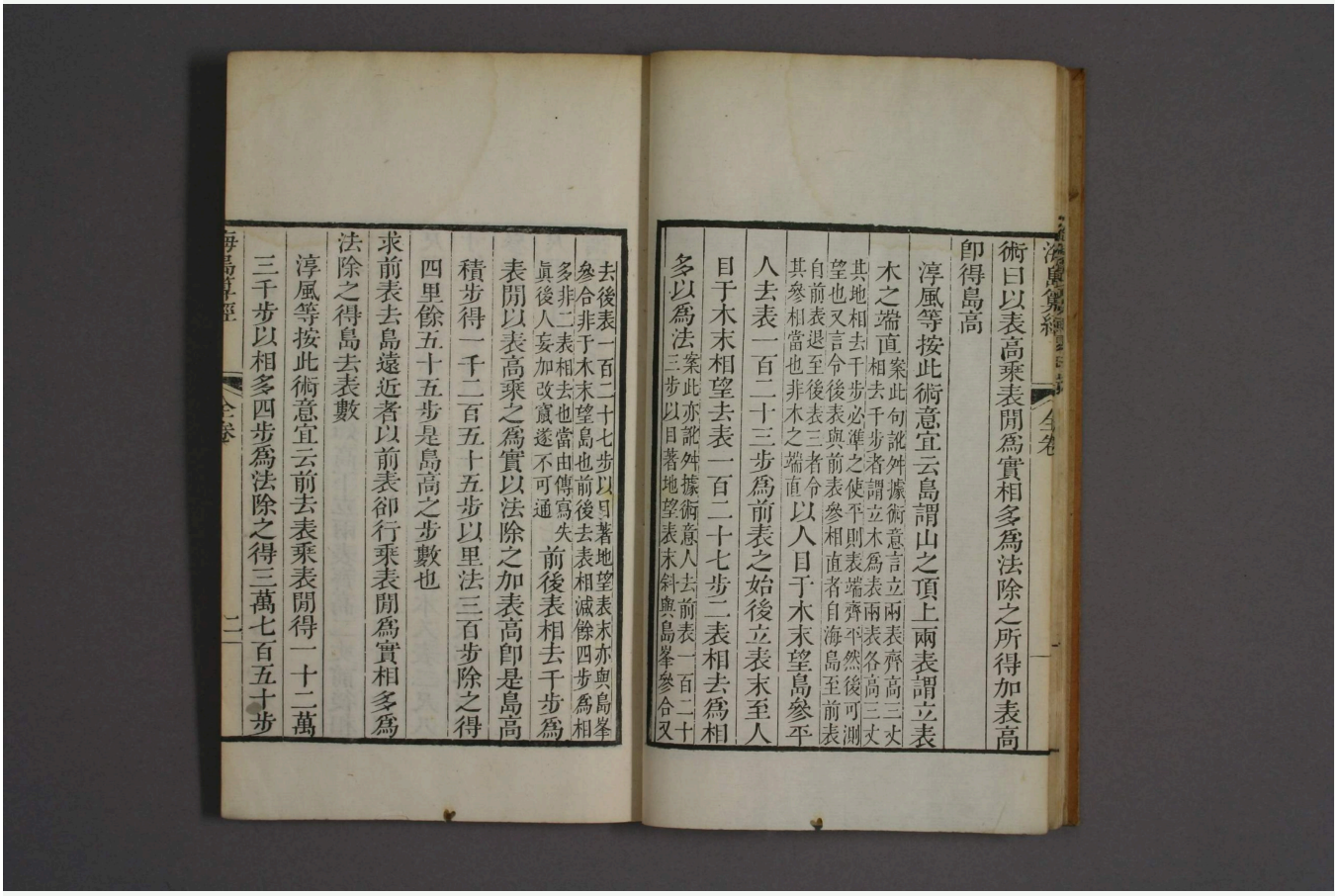
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Whole opening 10



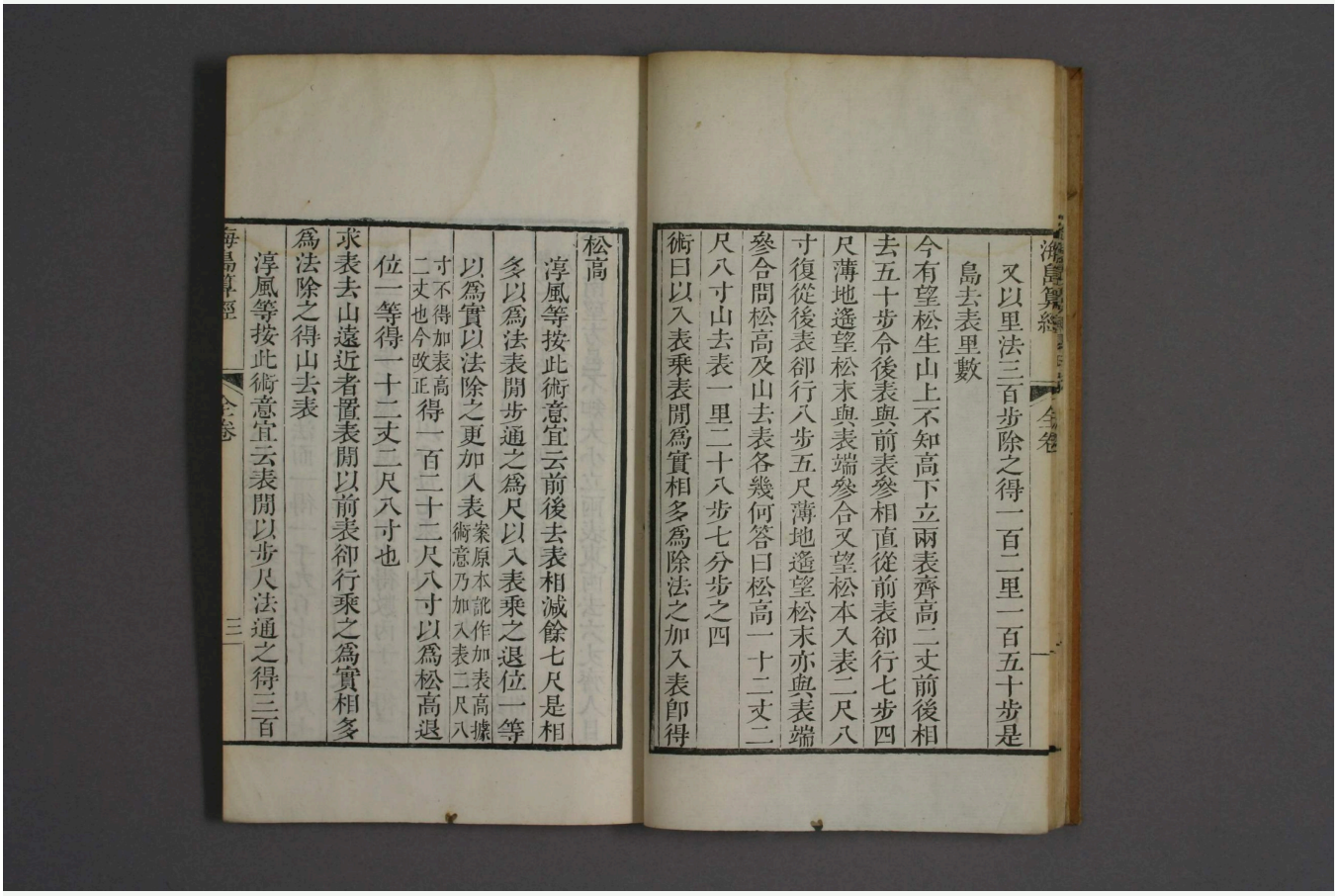
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Whole opening 11



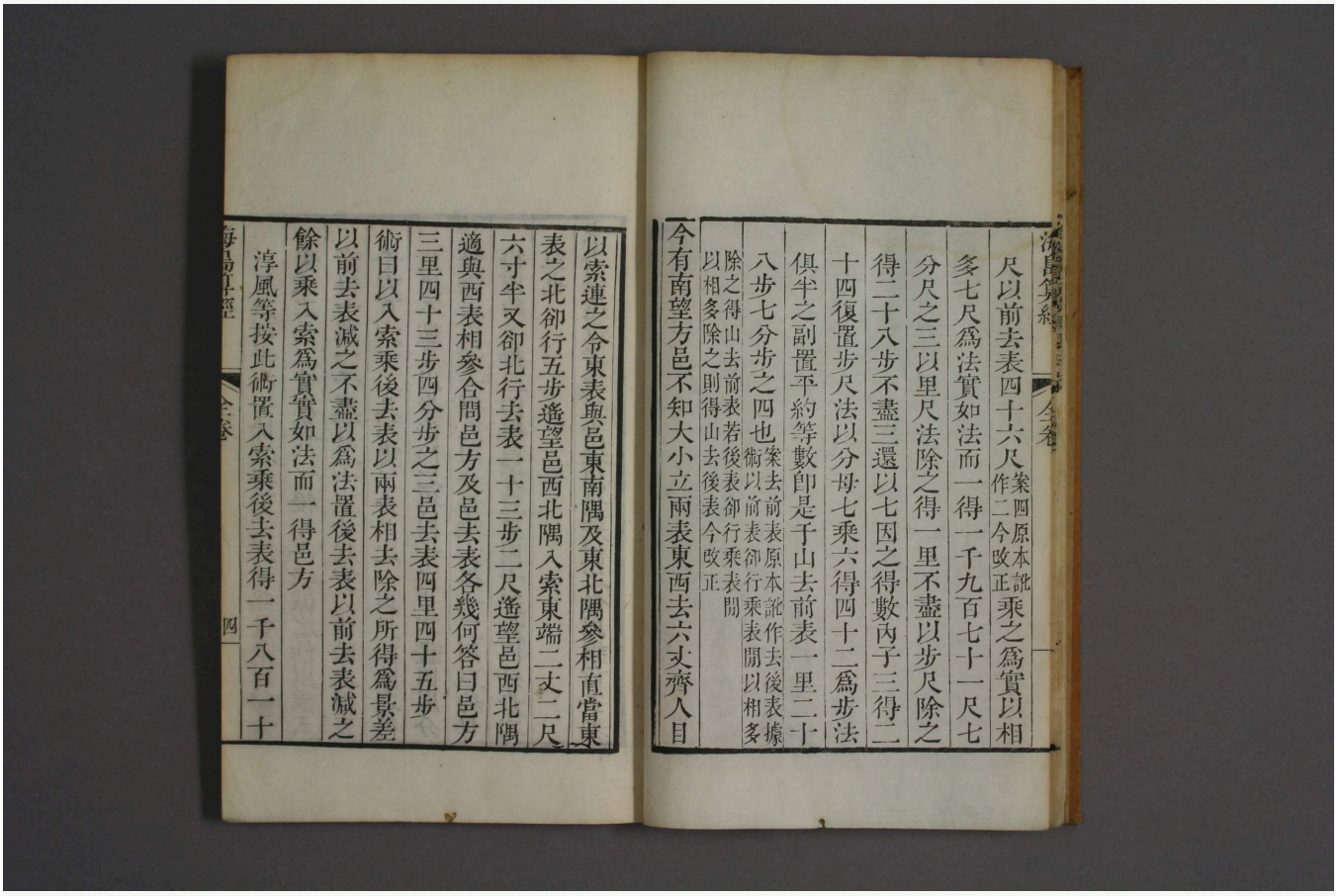
PDF page 11 · Waseda University Library ni02 00649; catalogue date 1777; preface dated 1775

Whole opening 12



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Whole opening 13



以索連之令東表與邑東南隅及東北隅參相直當東表之北卻行五步遙望邑西北隅入索東端二丈二尺六寸半又卻北行去表一十三步二尺遙望邑西北隅適與西表相參合問邑方及邑去表各幾何答曰邑方三里四十三步四分步之三邑去表四里四十五步

術曰以入索乘後去表以兩表相去除之所得爲景差以前去表減之不盡以爲法置後去表以前去表減之餘以乘入索爲實實如法而一得邑方

淳風等按此術置入索乘後去表得一千八百一十尺以前去表四十六尺案四原本訛作二今改正乘之爲實以相多七尺爲法實如法而一得一千九百七十一尺七分尺之三以里尺法除之得一里不盡以步尺除之得二十八步不盡三還以七因之得數內子三得二十四復置步尺法以分母七乘六得四十二爲步法俱半之副置平約等數卽是千山去前表一里二十八步七分步之四也案去前表原本訛作去後表據術以前表卻行乘表閒以相多除之得山去前表若後表卻行乘表閒以相多除之則得山去後表今改正

今有南望方邑不知大小立兩表東西去六丈齊人目

PDF page 13 · Waseda University Library ni02 00649; catalogue date 1777; preface dated 1775

Work the survey again

Record h, s, a and b:

Compute the height dividend hs:

What is 相多? Give a proposed divisor f:

Compute H = h + hs/f and D = as/f:

Front line at x = –D; candidate minus front:

Rear line at x = –D; candidate minus rear:

Choose allowed retreat intervals. Can b – a approach zero?

Exact machine-readable record

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